

Lab 05

Reviewing the Literature Assignment

Instructions

BEFORE you begin this activity, make sure that you have selected your final project dataset and core variable. You will want to use the articles you find during this activity to complete the references section of the Project Preproposal Worksheet.

The purpose of this activity is to help you learn more about your **core** variable and to identify at least three, peer-reviewed research articles to use for your final research project.

This worksheet will lead you through a series of steps designed to acquaint you with the literature search process. There are two parts to this worksheet: 1) completing this worksheet, as a way of documenting your ability to use various sources to compile a set of interrelated references, and 2) preparing an APA-style reference list of the articles resulting from your lit search.

You should be using Zotero to store and organize the articles you identify throughout this activity. As you find references, enter them as items into Zotero (make a new collection called *Lit Search worksheet* to keep them organized). You will create a citation for each one and enter it in the boxes provided as you go. This will also make the APA reference page at the end a simple one-click thing to create!

AFTER completing this worksheet, you should have identified at least 3 journal articles that can be used in your final project.

Searching the literature (30 points)

Step 1. Finding a start point (4 points)

Name the dataset and core variable you selected:

Your dataset name:

Your core variable name:

Now that you have identified a core variable for your project, your next step is to draft an initial conceptual definition, or a description of the behaviors, internal processes, or psychological construct it represents, as well as its relationship to other variables. This definition can start as a rough sketch or general understanding; it doesn't need to be perfect, as your understanding of the concept will evolve as you review the academic literature. Searching the literature will likely help to refine and adjust your conceptual understanding by providing more information about how other researchers have studied the topic (i.e., how they operationalized/measured your concept and explored its relationship to other

concepts). But you still need a place to start and provide your starting definition of your core construct here below.

Hint

This part of the process is absolutely vital as you will need to be searching for articles that discuss your core variable as a *construct* and not just as a scale or particular measure of that concept. For example, if you picked “Index of self-esteem” or “Boredom Proneness”, those things are the scales/surveys used to measure that variable. What we are searching here is the construct, or psychological concept, of what that variable is measuring, in those examples it would be “self-esteem” or “boredom”. If you do not pay attention to this, you will likely end up with a bunch of articles that scale construction and validation! And those articles include a lot of complicated math that you likely do not understand and is outside of the scope of this course! So, do not make things more difficult and take your time to situate yourself before jumping into your literature search!

Your core construct and its conceptual definition:

Now that we have an idea of what construct we are searching for, we want will want to find at least one “classic” or foundation reference that studied our core concept empirically and can help to situate us within the broader literature. In many cases, there will be an well-cited and relatively “old” article that first coined the term used in your core variable. In many cases, this might be the article that is chronologically oldest when you search for your concept as a search term in an academic database (but not always). But a “classic” article could also just be one that is very heavily cited in the field.

Using the APA Psycinfo database from the UNL Library Resources (Link: <https://libraries.unl.edu/>) perform an initial search of the literature using your core variable as a search term. Use a combination of the limits/filters/sorting features to identify the earliest/most important articles in this area.

Hint

When trying to identify which articles are most important or “classic” try taking a look at the number of citations each article has in your results list. Are there any references that stand out as particularly popular and well-cited? If so, start with those articles! Take a few minutes to read through the abstracts of those articles that might meet your criteria as a “classic” article and pick the article that seems like the best place to start based on your initial impression.

Also, remember that when using Zotero to collect and organize your references, you can either import the journal article PDF or use Zotero’s **Add Item by Identifier** tool with the article’s digital object identifier (DOI).

Using Zotero, create a reference page entry for the article you selected and paste it in the appropriate box below.

"classic" reference:

After identifying a foundational (classic) reference on your topic, you will also to identify the current state of the literature. More recent articles can help to explain how the field has developed over time,

and provide important information about the relationship between your core variable and other variables. It can also tell you the dominant theoretical and methodological trends in the area.

To identify a more recent “hot new” reference, conduct another search of the database, but this time focus on the items that have been published within the last 5 years. Skim the abstracts of the articles you find which might meet your criteria and select one particularly relevant or useful article as your “hot new” reference.

Hint!!

While you do not need to identify articles that mention any of the other variables in your dataset, it might be worth using that as another criteria guiding your selection process.

Using Zotero, create a reference page entry for the article you selected and paste it in the appropriate box below.

"hot new" reference:

Step 2. Expanding the search: Finding more recent articles (4 points).

Now that you have identified a classic reference (foundational work) and a hot new reference (current trends), you can use these articles to explore the broader literature. Instead of starting from scratch, return to your classic reference and use the “Cited by” feature in the database to locate three other recent articles (published within the last five years) that cite your classic reference.

Hint!!

Look for articles that seem to take a similar approach to studying your core variable. If you struggle to find any relevant articles, you may want to reconsider whether your classic reference is foundational to the field and return to Step 1. This is an entirely normal part of the process! Sometimes your assessment of a references relevance changes based on new information! If you already knew everything you needed to know about the topic before starting this process, you would not have needed to conduct a literature search in the first place!

Using Zotero, create a reference page entry for the three articles you selected and paste it in the appropriate box below.

Newer article 1 (within the last 5 years) that cited your “classic” starting reference:

Newer article 2 (within the last 5 years) that cited your “classic” starting reference:

Newer article 3 (within the last 5 years) that cited your “classic” starting reference:

Step 3. Expanding the search: Finding additional older material that was cited in your “hot new” reference (4 points).

Next, take another look at the article you identified as your “hot new” reference. Examine the references page for your “hot new” article and identify at least three articles from that list that might also be useful for your current research.

Hint!!

Do not just pick your articles from the list at random! Use the database to look up each references and try to learn more about them before making your decision. Review their citation statistics; how many times has the article been cited by other researchers? Skim the abstracts; what might this article tell me about the other variables in my dataset?

If you are having a really hard time finding three articles from the original references list, feel free to try using the references list of one of the articles that the “hot new” article cited! The purpose of this task is to practice using references pages to aid your literature search process.

Using Zotero, create a reference page entry for the three articles you selected and paste it in the appropriate box below.

Article 1 referenced in your “hot new”, or other recent, references:

Article 2 referenced in your “hot new”, or other recent, references:

Article 3 referenced in your “hot new”, or other recent, references:

Step 4. Finding the “Scope” and “Structure” of your topic (4 points).

For students conducting literature reviews is it particularly challenging to try to identify key search terms or evaluate the quality of individual articles when they are still unfamiliar with the terminology used in a particular field. This is particularly frustrating for psychology students because most journal articles are focused primarily on the reporting the results of an experiment(s) and therefore tend to only provide a small window into the broader literature on the topic. One solution to this problem is to seek out “review” or “encyclopedia” articles that are meant to provide a more general overview of the topic’s scope and structure. These reviews tend to provide more comprehensive overviews and include information about what other fields are commonly connected to your topic and whether there are subtopics that are commonly studied.

Two great places to find these types of review articles are Encyclopedias and the Annual Review of Psychology. Using the UNL Library databases, find at least one entry in either an online Encyclopedia or the Annual Review of Psychology that discusses your core variable topic.

Hint!!

Keep in mind that there may not be an entire review article or encyclopedia chapter dedicated to your topic. Often, you will have to look at chapters that are broader than your topic choice (e.g., if your topic were schizophrenia, you might consider chapters on psychopathology or clinical assessment).

Using Zotero, create a reference page entry for the Encyclopedia entry or Annual Review article you selected and paste it in the appropriate box below.

Annual Review or Encyclopedia (highlight one):

Step 5. Using PsycINFO to add search terms with the core variable (4 points).

Now that you have located a number of relevant articles (including the review article from Step 4), skim them and try to identify any keywords or phrases that have been used in relation to your core variable. Select at least one of these terms or phrases and use it to conduct a search in APA PsycINFO (combine your new keyword or phrase with the term you first used to search for your core variable/construct).

- Your ultimate goal is to generate a focused list of **~30–100 results**. Fewer than 30 may mean your search is too narrow, potentially missing valuable studies, while more than 100 can be overwhelming to review. Use the table below to document your search process.
 1. **Search:** Start by pairing your core variable with one keyword (e.g., “anxiety AND coping strategies”). Record the number of hits.
 2. **Refine:** If results are too few (<30), try alternative keyword pairings. If results are excessive (>100), apply filters (e.g., publication date, methodology) or add a third term using: AND to narrow focus (e.g., “anxiety AND coping strategies AND adolescents”). NOT to exclude irrelevant topics (e.g., “(Working Memory AND Attention) NOT Algorithm”).
 3. **Repeat:** Adjust the search terms and filters as needed until you reach the 30–100 range. Record each attempt in the table below.

Table 1

Terms Used	Limits/Filters	# of hits	What to try next?
1			
2			
3			

From your refined PsycINFO search results (aiming for 30–100 items), carefully review the list and select three references that may be useful to your research.

Using Zotero, create a reference page entry for each article(s) you selected and paste it in the appropriate box below.

Reference 1:

Reference 2:

Reference 3:

Step 6. Author Searches (4 points).

Another helpful strategy is to try to locate other research that has been conducted by the authors of the articles you have already found. Review the articles that you have collected thus far, are there any names that appear multiple times? Pay attention to both first and last authors, as disciplinary conventions vary on authorship order (e.g., in some fields, the last author is the senior researcher, while in others, the first author holds primary responsibility). If you're unsure, consult your TA for guidance on norms in your specific area.

Once you identified at least one recurring author, conduct a new search in PsycINFO by combining their name (as Author) with another keyword or phrase related to your topic. For example, if you find that Dr. Paris Geller frequently publishes on bullying, you might search: AU: "Geller, P." AND "bullying"

This approach can help you locate other work by prominent experts in a particular field while keeping the number of hits somewhat manageable. additional work by experts in your field while keeping results manageable. Aim for 10–30 hits for a particular search, but use your best judgment. You should adjust your expectations based on the researcher's career stage (e.g., early-career scholars may have fewer publications). Your ultimate goal is to generate a final list of **~10–30 results**. As in Step 5, use the table below to document your search process.

Hint!!

Many academics will also have personal websites where they list **all** their publications. If you have having a hard time using the databases, using Google to track down the author on the world-wide-web is often an effective work-around to help you get started.

Table 2

Terms Used	Limits/Filters	# of hits	What to try next?
1			
2			
3			

From your refined PsycINFO search results (aiming for 10–30 items), carefully review the list and select three references that may be useful to your research.

Using Zotero, create a reference page entry for the article(s) you selected and paste it in the appropriate box below.

Reference 1:

Reference 2:

Reference 3:

Wasn't that fun?

That is enough for now. But keep in mind that usually what you have just accomplished would only be the “first round” of a literature search. As you critically read each article, you would make a more informed decision about its quality and also identify additional “gaps” in the literature that would be worth exploring. The process of searching the literature is iterative, and in most cases, never-ending! Yay!

Create an APA Reference Page (6 points)

Now that you have collected at least 12 references that could be used in your final project, use Zotero to create an APA formatted references page listing them all on the next page.

Final thoughts!!

Hopefully, this activity helped you to identify at least three, empirical peer-reviewed journal articles that can be used in your final project and to complete the references section of the Project Preproposal worksheet.

References

Delete this and paste references list here.